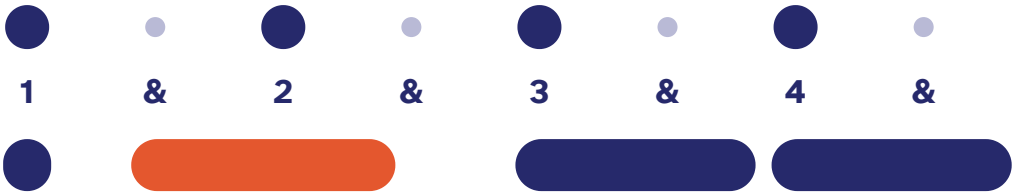
PART II · TIME · 7

# Rhythm: off the beat

Now the fun part: rhythm that teases the beat. It only works if the beat underneath stays rock-steady.

**THE SECRET**

**Keep the beat rock-steady and let the rhythm tease it.**




**starts on “&”, held over beat 2**

*A note between the beats*

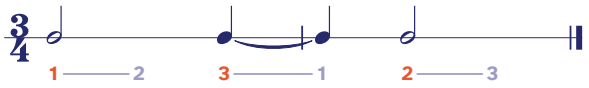
## Syncopation




The crotchet starts on “&” and is held through beat 2.

Level 4. Feel beat 2 even though nothing is played on it.

## Hemiola




Two bars of 3/4 felt as three minims.

Level 4. Common at cadences in Baroque dances.

## Swing Level ½

Common from the first pieces: jazz, blues and many easy modern pieces are marked *swing*. Pairs of quavers are written evenly but played **long–short**, like the first and last notes of a triplet.



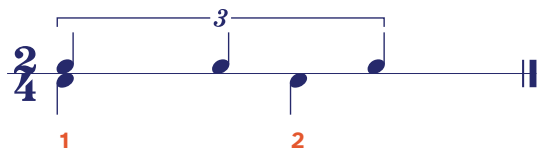
Written




Played

PART II · TIME · 7 · CONTINUED

## Polyrhythm Level 7




Three against two: a crotchet triplet above, two crotchets below, starting together.

## Rubato Extra

Time is stretched and then given back, for expression: the music leans into a phrase and catches up after it. The pulse always returns. Marked *rubato*, or simply part of the style in much Romantic music.

EXAMPLE

### Count a syncopation
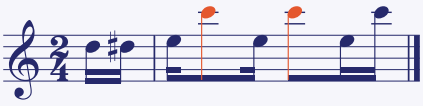



1. **Tap the beats:** 1, 2.
2. **Find the red crotchet:** it starts on the "&", between the beats.
3. **Hold it through beat 2**, then play bar 2 on the beats.

The accent falls **off the beat**: that is syncopation.

YOU KNOW THIS

### The Entertainer (Scott Joplin)



The high **C** keeps landing just after the beat, not on it: syncopation, the bounce of ragtime.

**Try it.** Tap the beat with your foot and hum the tune: hear the C slip between the taps.

THINK OF IT Syncopation is a skip in your walk: a step that lands between the beats. Swing is walking with a spring in your step, long-short, long-short. Rubato is borrowing time like pocket money: whatever you spend, you pay back.

TRAP

- × Rushing the short notes after a long one: keep counting inside the long note.
- × Playing a triplet unevenly: three equal notes, not two quick and one long.
- × Letting syncopation drag the pulse: tap the beat with your foot.

SEE ALSO

Rhythm: groups and upbeats p. 45 · Words for how to play: Expression (later)

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Levels ½–4 · Rhythm · Online: Rhythm clock